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Instrument 17 — The Pilot-System Selection Checklist (for Vendors) *(Chapter 16)*

Underwrite the institution the way an investor underwrites you. Ownership: who owns this internally, and have you met them, not heard about them? Is the champion's chain of command engaged and aligned *before* the pilot, starting with the executive the champion reports to? Path: what process will evaluate the pilot; who can say yes afterward; who can say no; is the pilot tied to a buying decision or to curiosity? Criteria: what converts this pilot; what kills it even if users love it; are success metrics agreed in writing up front? Capacity: does the institution have the training and change capacity to deploy honestly; is there a governance lane, or leadership willing to build one? Truth test: will this customer teach us repeatable truth or custom chaos — will their reference call (Instrument 15) someday be one we would want taken? Red flags: no executive owner; no decision path; champion structurally alone; senior leadership able to override the closest operator with no defined evaluation; "innovative" reputation with no named owner; a pilot accepted with no end date. Rule: the wrong pilot customer gives a startup false confidence; the right one gives it reusable truth. Champion path: does the champion have a path? First-customer training effect: what will this customer teach our company? Reference-call future: would we want this institution to be the reference call Chapter 15 asks buyers to make?